



Incident handler's journal

Instructions

As you continue through this course, you may use this template to record your findings after completing an activity or to take notes on what you've learned about a specific tool or concept. You can also use this journal as a way to log the key takeaways about the different cybersecurity tools or concepts you encounter in this course.

Date: August 24, 2026	Entry: 1
Description	Analysis and documentation of a ransomware security incident affecting a small U.S. primary-care healthcare clinic. The incident involved a targeted phishing campaign in which malicious email attachments were used to deliver malware, allowing attackers to gain access to the organization's network and deploy ransomware. The ransomware encrypted critical files, including medical records, resulting in significant disruption to the clinic's business operations and preventing employees from accessing essential systems and data.
Tool(s) used	Incident Handler's Journal No cybersecurity investigation tools were used during this activity. The incident was analyzed based on the provided security incident scenario and documented using the incident handler's journal.
The 5 W's	Who: An organized group of unethical hackers caused the incident. The attackers targeted organizations in the healthcare and transportation industries and used targeted phishing emails to gain initial access to the healthcare clinic's network.

	What: The attackers sent phishing emails containing malicious attachments to several employees. After an employee downloaded a malicious attachment, malware was installed on the employee's computer, allowing the attackers to gain access and deploy ransomware. The ransomware encrypted critical company files, including medical records, preventing employees from accessing essential data and software. The attackers then displayed a ransom note demanding money in exchange for the decryption key. When: The security incident occurred on a Tuesday morning at approximately 9:00 a.m. Employees began reporting that they were unable to access files and software needed to perform their jobs and that ransom notes were displayed on their computers. Where: The incident occurred within the computer network and systems of a small U.S. healthcare clinic specializing in primary-care services. The attack affected employee computers, critical files, medical records, and other systems required for the clinic's daily operations. Why: The attackers gained initial access through targeted phishing emails containing malicious attachments. When the malicious attachment was downloaded, malware was installed on an employee's computer, providing the attackers with a means to gain access to the organization's network and deploy ransomware that encrypted critical files.
Additional notes	Immediate Response and Remediation Affected computers should be isolated from the network to help prevent the ransomware from spreading to additional systems. Incident response and containment procedures should then be initiated, and available backups should be verified to determine whether affected systems and data can be safely restored without paying the ransom.

	Long-Term Prevention The organization should strengthen its defenses against phishing and malicious attachments by implementing secure email controls and attachment analysis or sandboxing. Additional security measures should include network access controls, the principle of least privilege, regular security awareness training focused on phishing detection, and reliable offline backups that can support recovery following a ransomware incident.
Key Incident-Response Takeaway	This incident demonstrates how a phishing email can serve as an initial access vector for a larger ransomware attack. It also highlights the importance of documenting security incidents, containing affected systems, maintaining reliable backups, and implementing preventive controls to reduce the likelihood and impact of future attacks.